STUDIES IN LANGUAGE

VOLUME 21 | NUMBER 1

1997

Offprint

JOHN BENJAMINS PUBLISHING COMPANY

STUDIES IN LANGUAGE

International Journal sponsored by the Foundation
"Foundations of Language"

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ISSN 0378-4177

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Studies in Language 21:1. 37–68 (1997). All rights reserved

OBJECT RELATIONS AND DATIVE CASE IN DOLAKHA NEWARI

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ABSTRACT

In Dolakha Newari, the dative case marks recipients of ditransitive verbs and some patients of monotransitive verbs. Quantative studies show that animacy and activation cost are both relevant in determining the distribution of dative case. Two theories on the syntactic status of objects in systems of this general type are shown to be inadequate for Dolakha. Instead it is found that there is no morphological or syntactic evidence for differentiating between classes of object in this language. Theories on the motivation of this pattern are considered, and it is concluded that it is best understood in terms of referent importance or topicworthiness.

1. Introduction

In Dolakha Newari,[1] the dative casemarker *=ta* is found marking goal-like arguments of ditransitive verbs (hereafter referred to as recipients), and some patient-like arguments of monotransitive verbs (hereafter referred to as patients).[2] Examples of each type are illustrated in (1) and (2) respectively:[3]

(1) *āpsin* ***āmta*** *wā hirā* *=e jā bir -ju*
3pl:ERG 3sg:DAT TOP diamond GEN rice give 3sg:PST[4]
'They gave him rice made of diamonds.'

(2) *chin* ***janta*** *da -syāt*
2sg:ERG 1sg:DAT PROH kill:IMP
'Don't you kill me.'

Note that *hirā =e jā* 'diamond rice', the patient NP of the ditransitive verb in (1), does not take *=ta* or any other casemarker; it is unmarked hence in the absolutive case.

Whereas all recipient arguments are indeed marked with the dative casemarker, only some patients of monotransitives are so marked; numerous examples of unmarked patients of monotransitives can be found, such as the following:

(3) *keṭā mwāl -hin hã*
boy search 3pl:PST HEARSAY
'It is said they looked for a boy.'

(4) *āme bā =n mebu misā hār -ai*
3sg:GEN father ERG other woman bring 3sg:PR
'Her father brings another woman.'

(5) *āle āpsin chẽ mi =n tir -hin*
then 3pl:ERG house fire INST ignite 3pl:PST
'Then they lit their house on fire.'

The factors which trigger the appearance of the dative casemarker on patients are semantic and pragmatic in nature, as will be demonstrated below.

This type of patterning, in which some patients of monotransitives have similar casemarking or other morphosyntactic behavior to recipients of ditransitives, is well attested in the world's languages, as illustrated in cross-linguistic studies dedicated specifically to this phenomenon by Blansitt (1984), Dryer (1986), Noonan (1991), La Polla (1992) and Masica (1982); Foley (1986: 101–102) also discusses this pattern in his description of the languages of New Guinea. The primary issue to be addressed in these languages is that of the syntactic status of patients of monotransitive verbs, both with and without casemarking. Does the casemarking indicate that patients of monotransitives and recipients hold a single grammatical relation with the verb, and if so, what is it? In Dolakha, this discussion must also include consideration of monotransitive patients which lack the dative casemarker. Another, more general issue is of course why dative case should be used to mark patients at all, in other words, what motivates this pattern.

This paper aims to address these two questions by providing an in depth study of the phenomenon in Dolakha Newari. In particular, it includes a quantitative study which explores the conditions under which the dative casemarker appears on patients of monotransitive verbs in narrative text (Section 2.0). Following this, it is argued that one cannot divide Dolakha objects into two separate classes based on morphosyntactic behavior (3.0).

Instead it will be shown that patients and recipients together form a single syntactic category of object, and that the assignment of casemarking in Dolakha is independent of grammatical relations.

1.1 *Theoretical Assumptions*

This paper is written within a functional-typological framework. There are two basic assumptions of this approach which are relevant to the current study and which I therefore state explicitly. First, it is assumed that evidence for syntactic categories is based upon language-particular morphosyntactic behavior. Contrary to work in Relational Grammar and Lexical-Functional Grammar, I do not assume that grammatical relations are primitive, nor do I assume that they are configurationally defined, as in Government and Binding Theory. Instead, I assume (following e.g. Keenan 1976, Comrie 1989, Borg and Comrie 1984, Gil 1984, Siewierska 1991, Mithun 1991, Van Valin 1993a) that the degree to which a language can be said to exhibit, for example, a subject, is dependent upon the degree to which the single direct argument of an intransitive clause and the agentive argument of a transitive clause have the same morphological and syntactic behavior. Thus some languages such as English or Dolakha may have very strong subjects, some languages such as Cayuga may have no subjects at all (Mithun 1991), and some, such as Kathmandu Newari, may have only weak subjects, in that there is only a small amount of behavior that characterizes the arguments grouped as subjects.

A second assumption of most practitioners of functional-typological theory is that there is only one level of syntactic structure, which is surface structure (this assumption is often implicit, as in Givón 1979, 1984, Comrie 1989, Langacker 1988, Croft 1990, and is sometimes made explicit, e.g. Van Valin 1993a). Distinctions between, for example, active and passive sentences, are not seen to be the result of movement rules which create a derived from an underlying structure, but are instead analyzed as grammaticalized constructions which reflect either historically or synchronically their basic semantic, pragmatic and discourse functions. Thus the English passive is accounted for not by a set of abstract rules relating levels of structure, but as a grammaticalized construction available to English speakers which reflects the function of the passive directly by placing the patient in the topical position of subject, and indicating the non-topical status of the agent by either ellipsis or oblique status (Givón 1979, 1984).

1.2 *Relevant background on Dolakha morphosyntax*

It is necessary to give a small amount of background on several aspects of the morphosyntax in order to facilitate the discussion and the analysis of examples. Further information on Dolakha can be found in Genetti (1988, 1994).

Dolakha is an ergative language. The ergative casemarker is *=na / =n* and is found with all subjects of transitive verbs: [5]

(6) *siru=n sir -ai*
Siru ERG know 3sg:PR
'Siru knows.'

(7) *jin thi-gur khã har-i*
1sg:ERG oneCL thing say 1:FUT
'I will tell you one thing.'

There is no evidence for any split in the ergative system, or for any semantic or pragmatic factors affecting the appearance of ergative case, such as aspect, agentivity, affectedness of objects, sociolinguistic factors, etc. (as is sometimes the case, see e.g. Hopper and Thompson 1980, Ochs 1982, 1988). Rather, ergative case seems to be strictly a reflection of the valence of the verb. Verbs which have semantic structures requiring more than one argument trigger ergative casemarking (even when the object is unspecific, non-referential or a cognate object).[6] Thus ergative case appears in transitive and ditransitive clauses, regardless of whether the patientive argument is realized by an NP (as in (7)) or is elided (as in (6)).

Despite the ergative casemarking system, there is strong evidence in Dolakha for the syntactic category subject, specifically comprised of the agentive argument of a transitive verb and the single core argument of an intransitive verb. As illustrated in Genetti (1994), the presence of Dolakha subjects is established by data from verb agreement, reflexivization, relativization, and clause-chaining constructions. Thus we can see that there is a clear independence of grammatical relations and the assignment of casemarking, with casemarking of subjects being dependent upon verbal valence.

Dolakha is a verb-final language. The order of the arguments preceding the verb is flexible, with all permutations of arguments attested frequently. The principles which govern the order of arguments have yet to be determined; they appear to be pragmatic in nature.

2. A quantitative study of the distribution of *=ta*

2.1 *Database and distribution of examples*

The database for this study was constructed out of a corpus of fifteen narrative texts elicited from eight native Dolakha speakers.[7] The texts were broken into sentences, the final clause of each sentence being identified by the presence of a finite verb, and the sentence break being made after sentence-final particles and any postposed arguments or adverbials. Each sentence then was broken into clauses; relative clauses were not considered separately as they are embedded modifiers within NPs. Once the data were so divided, they were imported into a relational database with each clause constituting one record.

The total number of clauses in the database is 2,623. Of these, 219 have either a recipient or patient argument casemarked by *=ta*. 102 examples are ditransitive with the recipient in dative case, 113 are monotransitive with the patient in the dative case, and 4 are exceptional in that they have ditransitive verbs with both the patient and the recipient in the dative case. An example of the latter is the following:

(8) *āle āmta bhānche =ta bir -ju*
then 3sg:DAT cook DAT give 3sg:PST
'Then he gave her (in marriage) to the cook.'

All four exceptional examples occur in the same text, and they describe arranged marriages. In the database there were no examples where the recipient was not marked by the dative case.

In addition to the examples casemarked with *=ta*, monotransitive examples with patient arguments which lack *=ta* are also relevant to this study. There are 387 such examples in the database. Of these, 112 do not contain true patients, as the non-subject arguments are either abstract (as in *chāmā phon-* 'beg for forgiveness') or cognate objects (such as *khã lār-* 'talk talk'). As abstract and cognate objects are never casemarked with *=ta* these examples have been excluded from the study, leaving a total of 275 monotransitive examples with patients which lack the *=ta* marker. The distribution of *=ta* in monotransitive and ditransitive clauses is summarized in Table 1: As all recipients in ditransitive clauses take the dative casemarker, the goal of the quantitative study was to determine the factors which control the

Table 1: Distribution of =ta in ditransitive and monotransitive clauses

Ditransitives —— Recipient only marked	102
Ditransitives —— Recipient and patient marked	4
Monotransitives —— Patient marked	116
Monotransitives —— Patient unmarked	275
Total	497

distribution of *=ta* on patients in the 391 monotransitive clauses. The factors which were found to be relevant are animacy and previous mention.[8]

2.2 *Animacy*

The first hypothesis to be tested by the quantitative study is given in (9):

(9) Animacy hypothesis 1:
Human and animate patients are casemarked by *=ta* whereas inanimate patients are not.

This hypothesis is based on suggestions that animacy is a relevant factor in the morphosyntactic treatment of objects in other languages (e.g. Ransom 1979, Comrie 1979, Masica 1982, Wallace 1981, Dryer 1986, Foley 1986, La Polla 1992, S. Thompson 1990. Indeed, Dryer (1986), citing personal communication with Scott DeLancey, specifically suggests that animacy may entirely control the distribution of dative case in some Tibeto-Burman languages).

In order to determine the role of animacy in the distribution of the dative casemarker, each patient of a monotransitive clause was coded for whether it was human, non-human animate or inanimate. Animals personified in narratives as evidenced by the ability to speak, think or feel emotion were coded as human, as were supernatural beings. Three examples contained patients which were ambiguous as to their animacy status. These came from a text in which a woman and her husband are convinced that she gave birth not to a human child but to a mortar and broom (*lungmā tuphi* 'mortar broom'). *lungmā tuphi* occurs as a patient several times throughout the narrative, sometimes as *lungmā tuphi mucā* 'mortar broom child'. Whether this referent is to be considered animate (since supposedly born of a woman) or inanimate (since actually composed of a mortar and a broom) is unclear.

These examples were excluded from the study (one example was casemarked by *=ta*, the other two were not).

The results of the animacy study are given in Table 2:

Table 2: Animacy of Patient NPs in Monotransitive Clauses

	Casemarked	**Non-casemarked**	**Total**
Human	112	41	153
Non-human Animate	4	28	32
Inanimate	0	203	203
Total	116	272	388

Clearly animacy is a relevant factor in the determination of dative case on patient NPs in Dolakha. In particular, it is clear that inanimate patients are not casemarked by *=ta*, an observation which naturally extends to the lack of casemarking on cognate and abstract objects. However, there are several ways of interpreting the results. If we consider the power of the form (dative case) to predict function (animacy), then very strong, virtually categorical, results are obtained:

(10) If dative case then animate: 100%
If dative case then inanimate: 0%

However, if we try to predict the appearance of the casemarker based on the function of animacy, the results are less satisfying:

(11) If animate then dative case: 62.7%
If animate then unmarked: 37.3%

This constitutes a skewed correlation in the sense of Givón (1992), and suggests that we must look for further factors that affect the distribution of dative case on animate participants.

It is clear that the Animacy Hypothesis 1, as written, is not born out by the study, as animacy does not in itself predict the appearance of the casemarker. However, a revised Animacy Hypothesis is supported, given in (12) below.[9]

(12) Animacy Hypothesis 2
Inanimate patients of monotransitive verbs never are casemarked with *=ta*.

Turning now to the human versus non-human animate distinction, Table 2 shows that a much larger percentage (73.2%) of human patients are casemarked with *=ta* than are non-human patients (12.5%). Thus it appears that with monotransitive verbs the dative casemarker is primarily reserved for human patients. Interestingly all four examples of non-human animate patients with *=ta* occurred at the climax of their respective stories, and the manipulation of these animate patients was crucial to the plot resolution. This suggests that it is only when non-human animate patients are of crucial importance that they are casemarked by *=ta*. Non-human animates will thus be excluded from the following discussion, which is aimed at finding what factors trigger the presence of the dative case on human patients.

2.3 *Previous Mention and Activation Cost*

It is clear that while animacy, and more importantly humanness, is one important factor in predicting the distribution of *=ta*, other factors are also relevant. The data from non-human animates are suggestive that the discourse status of an argument at the point of the discourse in which it appears should also be considered. Informal inspection of the texts indicates that some referents appeared as patients without *=ta* when first introduced into the text, but in patient positions with *=ta* later in the discourse. This fact suggested that previous mention may be a relevant factor in the distribution of the dative case. Thus the following hypothesis was tested:

(13) Hypothesis of Previous Mention
Human patients casemarked by *=ta* have been previously mentioned in the narrative in which they appear. Patients which are not casemarked are new in the narrative.

In order to determine the strength of this hypothesis, each casemarked human patient was coded for whether or not it had occurred previously in the narrative.[10] In most cases the determination of previous mention was straightforward. However, some consideration of the complexities of the spoken narrative required the following adjustments to be made in what would otherwise be a simple methodology:

1. Conversations embedded into the narrative were treated as separate mini-texts, based on the assumption that to replicate authentic conversation the frame for determining previous mention shifts from the speaker of the narrative to the character within the narrative who produces the direct quote.
2. False starts of sentences or episodes were not counted.
3. Clauses which were exact or near exact repetitions of the preceding clause were excluded from the counts. An example of this is the following:

(14) *āme bā =n mebu misā har -ai*
3sg:GEN father ERG other woman bring 3sg:PR
'Her father brings another woman.'

mebu misā har -ai
other woman bring 3sg:PR
'He brings another woman.'

mebu misā ha -i donk -e
other woman bring INF finish PART
'Having brought another woman...'

In this case only the patient in the initial clause was counted for previous reference. The other two clauses were considered to be repetitions of the same predication.

The results of the previous mention study are given in Table 3:

Table 3: Casemarking and Previous Mention of Human Patients

	Casemarked	**Non-Casemarked**
Previously Mentioned	111	7
New	1	34
Total	112	41

χ^2=114.48, p>.001

The results are quite striking and indicate a clear pattern. Over 99% of the casemarked examples were found on participants who had been mentioned previously, while almost 83% of the non-casemarked examples occurred with new participants. A chi-square test indicates that the probability that these

results are attributable to chance is less than 1%. Recall that the narratives which were the basis for this study were actually produced by eight different speakers. Some speakers produced numerous examples of human patients, whereas others produced much less. In order to be certain that the distribution found in Table 3 was not skewed by the production of one or two speakers, but was true for the group as a whole, the same test was performed on the data from each speaker independently. The distribution of examples for each speaker and the results of the statistical analysis are given in the Appendix. Here it will be noted that the pattern was consistent across all eight speakers, and that the results of the statistical test were significant at either the 1% or the 5% level of significance (the 5% level being obtained for speakers with fewer examples). Thus the pattern is robust in all speakers tested.[11] Based on the data presented in Table 3, it is clear that the Hypothesis of Previous Mention is supported.

Although we have found a clear correlation between previous mention and the presence of the casemarker, it should not be assumed that the dative case is simply used to mark previous mention, or that speakers conduct some sort of mental scan for earlier reference to a participant each time a human patient is referred to. From what we understand about the complexities of information flow in discourse, such an approach would clearly seem simplistic. Instead, the current results may be interpreted in terms of current theories of discourse and participant reference.

The distinction between previous mention and new is clearly reminiscent of the well known distinction between given and new (Chafe 1976), which has now been expanded to include an intermediate category "accessible" (Chafe 1987, 1992). I will adopt Chafe's terminology in referring to given, accessible and new as "activation costs". They may be defined as follows:

(15) 3 Activation Costs (Chafe 1987, 1992)

Given concepts are those which the speaker considers to be active for the hearer at the time of reference (in the hearer's current focus of consciousness).

Accessible concepts are those which the speaker judges to be semiactive for the hearer (in the hearer's peripheral consciousness).

New concepts are those which the speaker judges to be neither given nor accessible.

Givenness can be established either through the extralinguistic context shared by speaker and hearer, or the linguistic context of previous mention. Participants are accessible if they have been mentioned in the discourse, but have moved out of focal consciousness due to the addition of more active participants or change in episodes or paragraph boundaries (Chafe 1987: 29). Accessible participants may also be invoked via schema, a cluster of interrelated concepts. For example, in a conversation about a basketball game, the basketball, hoop, referee, shot clock, and other related concepts come into peripheral consciousness automatically. New participants are those not previously mentioned or invoked via schema.

If the dative case in Dolakha is coding activation cost as opposed to simply noting whether or not a participant has been previously mentioned, then there should be evidence for this in places where activation cost and previous mention do not match up in a one-to-one manner. Such evidence is found when we examine the counter-examples to the pattern in which previously mentioned human patients are marked with dative case.

Three examples had human patients which had been previously mentioned in the narrative, but had not been referred to for significant lengths of time (previous references were 105, 181, and 292 clauses back, respectively). When they were reintroduced into the narrative in the patient role, these earlier participants were not casemarked by *=ta*. If we were to assume that the dative case simply marked previous reference, then these examples could not be explained. Within the theory of activation cost, however, these examples are accounted for, as the previous mentions were so much earlier that the speakers could not assume that the hearers still retained these characters even in peripheral consciousness. Hence the speakers chose to reintroduce them as new. It might be noted in this regard that the plots of the two narratives in which these three examples were found had numerous twists and turns, and that the reintroductions of the participants were not expected or foreshadowed. These facts strongly suggest that it is given or accessible activation cost, as opposed to simple previous mention, that the speaker is attending to.

The single apparent counterexample where *=ta* appears on a patient NP which encodes the first mention of a referent may be analyzable as accessible through the invocation of a schema. In this text, a crown prince is arranging a second marriage for his father, the king. The bride's father is

concerned about her position after the king dies and the crown prince assumes power. He says:

(16) *chana bihaiti =ta =uri chin chẽ =ku ta -ina*
2sg:GEN legal.wife DAT TOP 2sg:ERG house LOC put FUT
'You will put your legal wife in the house.'

This is the first mention of such a wife, but since it is generally assumed that crown princes will marry and have children, and the schema is power and position within a royal family, such a participant is expected to appear, hence the activation cost in this example is accessible, not new. Once more, we see that the cognitive notion of activation cost, as opposed to previous mention, controls the distribution of casemarking.[12]

For the remaining four counterexamples which were previously mentioned but which lack the dative casemarker, it is possible to give *ad hoc* explanations for each one which may explain the lack of casemarking. For example, in one case the referent was generic as opposed to specific. In another, three participants which had only appeared separately were brought together as a group for the first time. And in the last two, there were major episode boundaries between mentions. However, as these factors did not seem to play a role in the casemarking of other examples in the database, we should be cautious in positing these factors as clearly explanatory. Factors not considered in the current study may play a part in these examples.

2.4 *Conclusions of the quantitative study*

From the study of animacy and previous mention we can draw the following conclusions. Inanimate NPs are never casemarked by *=ta*, animate non-human NPs may be casemarked by *=ta* if given and crucial to the story at the time of mention. Human NPs casemarked by *=ta* are either given or accessible.

Animacy and activation cost are both factors that contribute to the overall importance, or "topicworthiness" (S. Thompson 1990) of a referent. Animate and in particular human referents are inherently more important than inanimates (Ransom 1979, Givón 1984a,b) (all other things being equal; the relative importance of specific human and inanimate referents may be reversed in certain discourse contexts). And arguments increase in topicality (in the sense of Givón 1983) once they have been introduced, commented upon, and integrated into the discourse. Thus while this study has examined animacy and activation cost in particular, it may be seen as adding to the growing body of evidence that referent importance or "topicworthiness" (S. Thompson 1990) has a crucial role in determining morphosyntactic structure.

3. The syntactic status of patients and recipients in Dolakha

I will now turn to a discussion of the syntactic status of patients and recipients in Dolakha. I will begin by discussing two earlier proposed analyses of similar data, these being Dryer's (1986) theory of primary objectivity, and Noonan's (1991) postulation of a rule of Antidative Shift. I will demonstrate that both of these approaches are problematic for Dolakha. I will then argue that patients and recipients together form a single syntactic category "object" in Dolakha, and that there is not sufficient morphosyntactic evidence to justify further division of the object category.

3.1 *Primary objectivity*

Dryer (1986) distinguishes between two types of languages in terms of their treatment of objects. Primary object languages are those in which the patient of the monotransitive predicate and the recipient of the ditransitive predicate receive the same morphosyntactic treatment, hence form a syntactic category "primary object" (PO). This contrasts with the category "secondary object" (SO), which includes patients of ditransitive predicates. Primary object languages are distinguished from direct object languages. The latter have the more traditionally recognized pattern in which patients of both monotransitive and ditransitive verbs form a single syntactic category "direct object" (DO) in contrast to recipients which fall into a separate category of "indirect object" (IO). These two patterns may be represented as in Figures 1 and 2 (based on Dryer 1986: 814):

	Secondary Object	**Primary Object**
Ditransitive	Patient	Recipient
Monotransitive		Patient

Figure 1: Primary Object Language

	Direct Object	Indirect Object
Ditransitive	Patient	Recipient
Monotransitive	Patient	

Figure 2: Direct Object Language

It is clear that Dolakha does not neatly follow either of these patterns. When patients are casemarked they are receiving the same treatment as recipients of ditransitive verbs, hence for these cases Dolakha appears to be a primary object language. Indeed, if one were to work only with limited elicited data, one would probably reach this conclusion. On the other hand, the numerous examples of non-casemarked patients in discourse show that in terms of casemarking the patients of monotransitives and ditransitives are being treated in the same manner, which would argue that Dolakha follows the opposite pattern and is in fact a direct object language.

One possible avenue by which one might reconcile the data with the theory is to analyze Dolakha casemarking as being a split system, in other words, a system in which both primary and direct objectivity are attested. In monotransitive predicates with patients which are human and given or accessible, the patient has the same morphosyntactic behavior as recipients of ditransitives, hence the primary object pattern. On the other hand, monotransitive patients which do not have these semantic and pragmatic properties are given the same morphosyntactic treatment as ditransitive patients, hence the direct object pattern is attested. On this analysis, Dolakha appears to exhibit a split in the object marking pattern, a phenomenon referred to by Dryer (1986: 827) as split objectivity.[13] This pattern would constitute a nice parallel to split ergative casemarking systems which can also have semantic motivations; for example, the Nepali ergative system is split by aspect.

While this analysis seems appealing, however, it does contain a major flaw, namely indeterminacy of the syntactic structure of ditransitive examples. This is most easily illustrated through the labelling of syntactic relations in the following examples:

(17) *pānduk =ta rāje bir -ju*
Pānduk DAT kingdom give 3sg:PST
PO SO
'(He) gave the kingdom to Pānduk.'

(18) *āpsin balaku keti twāŋsona =ta khon -ju*
3pl:ERG **beautiful girl Twāŋsona** DAT see 3sg:PST
PO
'They saw the beautiful girl Twāngsona.'

(19) *pānduk =ta rāje bir -ju*
Pānduk DAT **kingdom** give3sg:PST
IO DO
'(He) gave the kingdom to Pānduk.'

(20) *kwākarbeŋ =na āpāĩ sā nar -ŋasin*
frog ERG like.this **cow** eat when
DO
'When the frog ate a cow like this...'

Examples (17) and (18) illustrate the primary object pattern, while examples (19) and (20) illustrate the direct object pattern. The problem is that examples (17) and (19) are the same sentence. When contrasted with a monotransitive clause with a *=ta* marked object, this sentence appears to contain a primary and a secondary object. When contrasted with a monotransitive example without *=ta*, however, it appears to contain an indirect and a direct object. Since there is nothing within the ditransitive clause itself to trigger a change in the syntactic structure, there is no reason to postulate more than one syntactic analysis. This syntactic indeterminacy resulting from the split objectivity hypothesis leads to its immediate rejection.

If the split object analysis must be rejected, the question remains as to whether the Dolakha data can fit into Dryer's division of primary and direct object languages. If, given the data in (17) and (18), we conclude that the rule which assigns dative case in Dolakha operates on a primary object basis, then the patients of monotransitive verbs which lack casemarking, as in (20), must necessarily be secondary objects. This analysis would then require significant revisions in Dryer's theory, as clauses with secondary objects but no primary objects would be allowed in the absence of syntactic rules, a situation explicitly rejected by Dryer, and one which would weaken the

theory greatly. On the other hand, it is clear that case marking in Dolakha does not work on a direct object basis, since some of the patient arguments are marked with the dative morpheme, and some are not.

Another possibility would be to consider dative case assignment in Dolakha to be an **optional** rule that operates on a primary object basis.[14] The problem with this analysis is the infrequent but attested ditransitive examples in which both the patient and the recipient are casemarked (exemplified in (8)). The scarcity of such examples is clearly derived from the unusual discourse conditions which would give rise to such a casemarking pattern. However their presence in natural discourse clearly shows that any analysis which seeks to explain casemarking patterns by opposing object categories will not be adequate.

We can conclude that casemarked objects in Dolakha do not fit into either a primary object, a direct object, or a split object pattern. As will be shown below, there is no other morphosyntactic evidence which suggests the presence of either a PO/SO or a DO/IO distinction. It should be noted that, while not stated explicitly, there is nothing in Dryer's framework which excludes the possibility of a language which makes no distinction in object categories (Matthew Dryer, personal communication). Dryer's framework leaves open the possibility of a language in which all relevant rules operate on the basis of a single category of object. Dolakha is an example of this possibility.

3.2 *Anti-Dative Shift*

Noonan (1991), examining similar casemarking patterns in Chantyal (also a Tibeto-Burman language of Nepal), proposes a quite different analysis. He argues in favor of a rule of Anti-Dative Shift (ADS) (not to be confused with Dryer's rule of Antidative) which creates IOs from DOs, especially those which have some combination of the properties human, topicalized, partial affectedness, and specificity (1991: 54). Thus an example such as (18) would contain a direct object at one level of analysis which would then become an indirect object at a derived level as the result of ADS.

ADS operates under pragmatic conditions similar to those which control Dative Shift (DS) in languages such as English (e.g. Ransom 1979, S. Thompson 1990). However, as Noonan points out, ADS and DS are syntactic opposites. If DS is seen as a case of "promotion" along a hierarchy of grammatical relations SUB>DO>IO, then ADS appears to be a case of

"demotion". However the semantic and pragmatic properties of the arguments that undergo ADS are those of NPs which typically are given positions higher on the hierarchy, hence the demotion analysis is counterintuitive. One could argue instead that in these languages the order of the object categories in the hierarchy of grammatical relations is reversed, leading to a SUB>IO>DO pattern. Ideally, evidence for this reversal would be manifest in a number of different morphosyntactic areas in the grammars of the languages in question, a situation not found in Dolakha. Note also that Dryer states that "a language that treats IO's as higher then DO's is really a PO language" (1986: 819). But, as we have seen, the PO analysis is problematic.

As will be demonstrated below, the only known evidence by which one could argue for a division of Dolakha objects into DOs and IOs is casemarking. If there were independent arguments which showed that casemarked and non-casemarked objects in Dolakha had different morphosyntactic behavior, then one would feel justified in saying that there are two object grammatical relations in Dolakha. Since this is not the case, the postulation of ADS imposes a grammatical distinction not in evidence in the language, and only functions to account for the presence of the dative casemarker on patients. The grammar is simpler if it avoids the postulation of two levels of structure mediated by syntactic rules, and simply allows casemarking to be assigned independent of grammatical relations.

3.3 *Evidence for a single category "object" in Dolakha*

It is clear that in Dolakha there must be at least one grammatical category of object. That objects are distinct from subjects is shown by the casemarking facts presented, by the morphology of relative clause constructions (discussed below), and by other criteria which clearly distinguish subjects as a syntactic category (Genetti 1994). That objects are distinct from obliques is established by casemarking, and by the morphology of relative clause constructions. The goal of the arguments given below will therefore be to illustrate that there are no syntactic rules in this language that distinguish between categories of objects; that is, there are no rules which make a distinction between either DO/IO or PO/SO. This will be done by examining different types of syntactic behavior which are generally considered to be relevant to object categories cross-linguistically, specifically word order, relativization, reflexivization, and causatives.[15] If there were a distinction between object categories in Dolakha, and if casemarking were correlated

with one category as opposed to the other, then we should find additional evidence for this syntactic division in the independent morphosyntactic behavior of the two categories. However, no such evidence exists in Dolakha.

3.3.1 *Word Order*

Word order does not differentiate between object categories in Dolakha. In ditransitives, there is a strong tendency for the recipient to precede the patient, however, numerous examples where the order is reversed are found. Examples of both orders are the following:

(21) Recipient precedes patient:
āmta wā hirā =e jā bir -ju
3sg:DAT TOP diamond GEN rice give 3sg:PST
'(He) gave him diamond rice.'

(22) Patient precedes recipient:
sir-i teŋ -gu wāsā kījā =ta bir -ju
die INF about NR1 bull y.brother DAT give 3sg:PST
'(He) gave the dying bull to his younger brother.'

While the principles which determine word order in Dolakha have yet to be studied in depth, I assume that the pragmatic status of arguments plays a role in determining positioning. There is no evidence to date that the semantic role of objects is influential in determining word order, hence no evidence in favor of postulating distinct syntactic categories.

3.3.2 *Relativization*

In Dolakha, the verb of a relative clause is marked by one of two nominalizing/relativizing suffixes which I have labelled NR1 and NR2. The distribution of these two paradigmatic suffixes in nominalization and relativization is extremely complex and a full description is beyond the scope of the current paper (see Genetti 1994). In texts, the basic pattern of distribution is as follows. Examples where the head noun is coreferential with the elided subject of the relative clause use NR1. Examples where the head noun is coreferential with a patient or recipient object of the relative clause use NR2. In examples where the head noun is coreferential with an oblique noun phrase (such as a locative), either NR1 or NR2 can be used:

(23) Subject relative — NR1
ām pipāna ye -u mi -pen
that sitting.room come NR1 person PL
'The people who came into the sitting room'

(24) Object relative; patient — NR2
jin khoŋ-a keṭi
1sg:ERG see NR2 girl
'The girl whom I saw'

(25) Object relative; recipient — NR2
bisma haŋ-a kae
Bisma say NR2 son
'The son who is called Bisma'[16]

(26) Oblique relative — NR1
sivaji coŋ -gu ṭhāĩ
Sivaji stay NR1 place
'The place where Sivaji lives'

(27) Oblique relative — NR2
sonā pi -e ṭhāĩ
flower plant NR2 place
'The place where (you) plant flowers'

Thus we can see that the syntax of relativization makes a division between subject, object and oblique noun phrases, and that both patients and recipients are treated as objects. Relativization provides no evidence for a division into two object categories.

3.3.3 *Reflexivization*

In Dolakha, there are no true reflexive constructions in which the reflexive pronoun is an argument of the verb. However speakers of this language make extensive use of a possessive reflexive construction meaning "one's own". The reflexive pronoun *thau* is used to indicate a possessor coreferential with a subject. In order to indicate coreferentiality between a possessor and an object, the third person genitive pronoun *āme* is followed by a discourse particle which indicates contrast, *tuŋ*. Thus it is possible to elicit sentence pairs as follows:

(28) *Rām=na mucā thau mā =ta bir -ju*
Ram ERG child REFL mother DAT give 3sg:PST
'Ram gave the child to his own (Ram's) mother.'

(29) *Rām=na mucā āme tuŋ mā =ta bir -ju*
Ram ERG child 3sg:GEN CONT mother DAT give 3sg:PST
'Ram gave the child to his own (the child's) mother.'

āme tuŋ can also refer to recipients:

(30) *Rām=na Krisna =ta āme tuŋ kitāb bir -ju*
Ram ERG Krisna DAT 3sg:GEN CONT book give 3sg:PST
'Ram gave Krisna his own (Krisna's) book.'

Thus in Dolakha there is a single possessive reflexive construction used for both recipient and patient objects; there is no evidence for a division into two categories.

3.3.4 *Causatives*

In Dolakha causative constructions, the causee is syntactically the object of the causative verb. This argument can be either casemarked with the dative, or not:

(31) *dani jāki peŋ -gar ŋā -gar hā -k -e*
owner rice five CL six CL bring CAUS PART
'Making the owner bring only five or six measures of rice...'

(32) *āmta =ri ci khursāni ni -k -e*
3sg:DAT TOP salt chili grind CAUS PART
'Making her grind salt and chilis...'

The object status of the causee is evident from the lack of ergative casemarking which would be required considering the transitivity of the lower predicate in these examples. In (31) the object is simply *dani* 'owner' without the dative clitic, while in (32) the object is the dative pronoun *āmta*. If we were to assume that there were two distinct classes of objects, and that the presence versus absence of *=ta* marked this distinction, then causativization could not be said to distinguish between these two classes. Rather than saying that the causee in Dolakha holds either of two object grammatical relations, it is simpler to acknowledge that there is a single grammatical relation of object, and have a non-relational assignment of dative case.

4. Discussion

4.1 *The assignment of casemarking in Dolakha*

I have shown that four different syntactic structures which commonly differentiate categories of objects in the languages of the world do not do so in Dolakha. There is to my knowledge no other syntactic behavior in this language that could be said to differentiate object categories. The only possible morphological behavior which could be attributed to such a division is the presence of the dative casemarker. However using the dative as a diagnostic is problematic since the dative casemarker is found on patients as well as on recipients. While it is possible to retain an analysis whereby casemarking is the result of a division of grammatical relations, for example, by weakening Dryer's theory of primary objectivity, a much simpler analysis is obtained by allowing casemarking to be sensitive to semantic and pragmatic, rather than syntactic, factors. This analysis directly reflects the insights provided by the quantitative study, and does not require dividing Dolakha objects into two classes for which there is no evidence. The distribution of the casemarker may thus be summarized as follows:

(33) Distribution of dative casemarking on objects
All recipients
Human patients which are given or accessible
Non-human animate patients which are topical

Note that this system allows for the possibility of two objects marked with the dative case in ditransitive examples, a situation attested in texts and exemplified in (8) above. It also allows for a nice parallel for the assignment of ergative case, which also is not based on grammatical relations. Thus there is no one-one relation between cases and grammatical relations for either ergative or dative case.

When summarized as in (33), however, the distribution of the dative casemarker seems to be almost disjunctive. Recipient is a semantic case role where the presence of the dative case is obligatory (this is true even in the few cases where the recipient is non-topical or non-referential (though

recipients are never inanimate in this language), as in the sentence *gunta=ŋ da-hat* 'don't tell this to anybody').[17] Whether or not to assign dative case to patients, on the other hand requires a mix of semantic and pragmatic information. This pattern does make sense, however, in light of more general theories of motivation for these categories.

4.2 *Motivation for the casemarking of objects*

A number of articles have appeared in the last fifteen years discussing the interaction of the syntactic relations of objects with semantic and pragmatic categories (including Comrie 1979, Ransom 1979, Hopper and Thompson 1980, Mallinson and Blake 1981, Masica 1982, Blansitt 1984, Givón 1984a, b, Dryer 1986, Foley 1986, S. Thompson 1990, C. Thompson 1990, Croft 1990, La Polla 1992). The papers are remarkably similar in finding humanness, animacy, and various discourse pragmatic categories (including definiteness, referentiality, topicality, salience and topicworthiness) correlating significantly with morphosyntactic alternations evidenced in the behavior of recipient and patient objects. Thus the current study adds more evidence to this growing body of literature.

In this literature there are three primary explanations proposed for the correlations between semantic and pragmatic factors and the morphosyntactic behavior of objects. Comrie (1979), Masica (1982), Foley (1986) and La Polla (1992) suggest that marking of animate or definite objects is primarily caused by a need for disambiguation with agentive NPs. Since subjects of transitive verbs are overwhelmingly animate and definite (Comrie 1979, Givón 1976), the propositional semantic structure of clauses in which both the subject and the object share these features will be more difficult to recover than in clauses with inanimate or indefinite objects. Thus these authors claim that the pattern in which languages only mark objects which are animate and/or definite is motivated by the need for case recoverability.

Dryer (1986: 841) states that the primary motivation for the PO/SO distinction is discourse/pragmatic function. His argument is as follows. Since recipients tend to be more topical than patients in ditransitive clauses (see S. Thompson 1990), they constitute "secondary clausal topics" (in contrast to agentive NPs which are "primary clausal topics", Givón 1984b). In mono-transitive clauses, however, the only argument eligible to be a secondary clausal topic is the patient. He concludes "the PO/SO distinction can be viewed as a grammaticization of secondary topic versus non-topic". Dryer's

discussion does not refer to the role of animacy or particular pragmatic functions such as definiteness. However in his concluding remarks, Dryer acknowledges that a human/non-human distinction may be relevant for some primary object languages. Although none of the languages of his study have such a system, he speculates that a human/non-human distinction might serve as a diachronic source for primary objectivity, since human arguments tend to be topical as well.

Ransom (1979) examines the pragmatic status of patient and recipient arguments in English double object constructions. She finds that both definiteness-referentiality and humanness-animacy are relevant factors in determining the position of recipient arguments in English. She combines the two parameters into a single "salience hierarchy" and argues that the most salient of the two arguments will appear first in the clause. Since this study is restricted to English, the relative word order of the patient and recipient arguments is the primary formal realization of different pragmatic statuses. Ransom thus frames the explanation of her results in terms of order, stating that it is natural to order salient information first.

Of these three explanations, it is clear that neither the proposal by Ransom based on the ordering of salient information, nor the proposals put forth independently by Comrie, Masica, Foley and La Polla regarding disambiguation can be postulated as primary motivation for the pattern in Dolakha. Ransom's proposal is clearly inadequate for Dolakha since word order and the appearance of the dative casemarker are not correlated. The theory that disambiguation is the primary motivation for this pattern is untenable in the presence of a regular ergative pattern (as noted by Noonan 1991: 56). Since subjects of transitive verbs will always be marked as ergative, there is no need to use the dative casemarker to disambiguate the propositional semantics. Thus while disambiguation may be a secondary, redundant function of the use of dative case on patients, it cannot be the primary motivation for the pattern.

Dryer's analysis, based on the distinction between primary and secondary clausal topics, works well for a language where casemarking follows a true primary object pattern, but as Noonan (1991: 57) notes, it is not relevant for languages where only some patients are casemarked. If there are two arguments in a clause, why should the object NOT become the secondary clausal topic? In other words, we would expect all patients of mono-transitives to be casemarked, as in a true PO/SO system.

I believe that the Dolakha pattern is most easily explained by referring

again to the notion of referent importance or topicworthiness. In Dolakha, animacy and activation cost are the topicality factors which play a role in the distribution of the dative case. We can arrange these parameters on parallel hierarchies, alongside a similar hierarchy for case roles (cf. Silverstein 1976, Dixon 1979, Givón 1984, Comrie 1989, Croft 1990, Chafe 1992):

(34) Recipient > Patient
Human > Animate > Inanimate
Given > Accessible > New

The higher the ranking of an argument on these three hierarchies, the more likely it is to be casemarked as dative. Since recipients are overwhelmingly human and given, the presence of the dative case on this category is fully grammatical. The status of patients, on the other hand, varies significantly, as patients can hold any combination of features on either the animacy or the activation cost hierarchy. Only patients with rankings high on these scales may be casemarked. Note that the lower the patient on the animacy hierarchy, the more stringent the pragmatic requirements for dative case become; non-human animate patients must not only be given, they must also be playing a significant role in plot resolution to qualify for casemarking. And inanimates, at the lowest end of the hierarchy, are never casemarked. This analysis follows Dryer and others in recognizing that it is the topical status of recipients that allows for the reanalysis of dative casemarkers from a marker of recipient or indirect object, to a marker of topical objects in general.

5. Conclusion

This study has explored the factors affecting the distribution of the assignment of dative case in a language in which dative is extended to some patients of monotransitive clauses. Animacy and activation cost, factors which contribute to the overall topicality or "topicworthiness" of an argument were found to be excellent predictors of the assignment of dative case. In addition, it has been argued that Dolakha has only one syntactic category of object, and does not distinguish between either direct and indirect or primary and secondary objects. Dolakha thus constitutes an additional type to be added to our typology of object systems, and to be considered in the development of theories of grammatical relations.

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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This study has profited greatly from the aid of a number of scholars, especially from numerous discussions with Laura Crain. I am grateful to Wallace Chafe, Scott DeLancey, George van Driem, David Hargreaves, Randy La Polla, and Sandra Thompson for specific and valuable comments on an earlier draft of this paper. In addition, H. S. Gopal provided assistance on the design and statistical analysis of the quantitative aspects of this study. Also, anonymous reviewers for *SIL* provided many interesting and thought-provoking comments. Perhaps unwisely, I did not always take the advice provided to me; all errors are, of course, my own responsibility.

Funds for this study were provided by the National Science Foundation, grant BNS–8811773.

APPENDIX

Previous Mention Data by Speaker

Speaker 1:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	50	0
New	2	4
Total	52	4
$\chi^2 = 35.89$, $p < .01$		

Speaker 2:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	15	0
New	1	2
Total	16	2
$\chi^2 = 11.25$, $p < .01$		

Speaker 3:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	17	0
New	0	9
Total	17	9
$\chi^2 = 26$, $p < .01$		

Speaker 4:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	16	1
New	4	8
Total	20	9
$\chi^2 = 12.1$, $p < .01$		

Speaker 5:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	3	0
New	0	2
Total	3	2
$\chi^2 = 5$, $p < .05$		

Speaker 6:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	4	0
New	0	1
Total	4	1
$\chi^2 = 5$, $p < .05$		

Speaker 7:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	4	0
New	0	6
Total	4	6
$\chi^2 = 10$, $p < .01$		

Speaker 8:	*Casemarked*	*Non-Casemarked*
Previous Mention	2	0
New	0	2
Total	2	2
$\chi^2 = 4$, $p < .05$		

NOTES

1. Newari is a Tibeto-Burman language spoken in Nepal. While Dolakha is commonly referred to as a dialect, it is mutually unintelligible with the Kathmandu "standard" and all other dialects to my knowledge. For more information, see Genetti (1988, 1990).
2. I am using the terms "recipient" and "patient" loosely to characterize the set of case roles which generally translate into English with indirect and direct objects respectively. Thus my "recipients" can also semantically be beneficiaries, maleficiaries, goals, etc., while "patients" can also be themes, undergoers, etc. I regret this terminological inconsistency, but find it necessary in order to avoid confusion with terms for grammatical relations.
3. All examples are taken from narrative or conversation unless otherwise specified. The following abbreviations will be used in glosses:

1	First person	2	Second person
3	Third person	CAUS	Causative
CL	Classifier	CONT	Contrast
DAT	Dative	ERG	Ergative
FUT	Future	GEN	Genitive
IMP	Imperative	INF	Infinitive
INST	Instrumental	LOC	Locative
NR1	Nominalizer/Relativizer 1	NEG	Negative
NR2	Nominalizer/Relativizer 2	P	Plural verbal
PART	Participle	PL	Plural
PR	Present	PROH	Prohibitive
PRTC	Particle	PST	Past
REfl	Reflexive	sg	Singular
TOP	Topic particle		

4. Sometimes in Dolakha there is a lack of agreement in number between third person plural subjects and the verb. A similar pattern is found in Nepali (Genetti 1993a).
5. Dolakha casemarkers are morphological clitics except when occurring in pronouns. Pronouns have idiosyncratic phonological behavior which indicates that these paradigms have lexicalized. Therefore the casemarkers are not divided morphologically in either the representation or the glosses of pronouns. For more information on this subject, see Genetti 1993b.
6. Dative subject constructions are exceptional in this regard. They appear to be lexically specified and are few in number.
7. The narratives consisted of folk tales, first person narratives, parts of Hindu epics, and relations of events in the village of Dolakha. Speakers ranged in age from 17 to over 60 and represented both sexes. There was no evidence in the data of any variation based on either speaker status or narrative type.
8. An anonymous reviewer from *SIL* has suggested that features of the verb may also be relevant. No evidence in favor of this hypothesis was found, as many verbs were found co-occurring with both marked and unmarked objects. A pair of sentences illustrating this fact follows:

   (1) *mucā -pen nis -mā nāplang-ane*
   child PL two CL meet PART
   'Having met the two children...'

   (2) *kho =e dāti =ku mi =ta nāplat-cu.*
   river GEN middle LOC man DAT meet 3sg:PST
   '(He) met the man in the middle of the river.'
9. It should be noted that there is one counterexample to this claim (cited in Genetti 1994), found in conversational data which is not included in the database:

   A. *o =ta ultā yeng-an keng-gu*
   this DAT translation do PART show NR2
   ju-en con-a ka
   be PART stay.3sg:PST PRTC
   'It turns out she translates this and shows it to people.'
10. The original study actually calculated the "referential distance" or distance to the immediately preceding reference in terms of clauses for each relevant argument (following the methodology established in Givón 1983). It was found that distance to previous reference was not a relevant factor until that distance was greater than one-hundred clauses.
11. Note that the fact that significant patterns of distribution were found for each speaker allows us to justify the use of chi-square for the combined data of all eight speakers, represented in Table 3.
12. In the remaining thirty-four examples which lack casemarking, three others include object referents which one may argue are invocable by schema. In all three (found in two different texts), the schema is marriage arrangements. The object referents in all three examples are generic, representing in each case the class of potential suitors to be considered. This genericity may be having an effect on casemarking; I will leave this question for future study.
13. This treatment of split-objectivity actually differs in a crucial respect from Dryer's theory; in the latter split-objectivity is a property of rules, such that some rules work in a primary object pattern while others work in a direct object pattern. Here a single rule, the assignment of dative case, is said to produce a split system. Note that in the literature on split-ergativity both types of systems are found. Nepali is an example of the latter, in that a single rule assigning ergative case results in a split-ergative system.
14. I am grateful to an anonymous *SIL* reviewer for suggestion and discussion of this point.
15. Dolakha does not have a passive construction.
16. Note that the non-relativized form of this clause is *āmun kae=ta bisma hatcu* 'he called his son Bisma' or 'he said to his son "Bisma"'.
17. In elictation, one informant accepted this sentence without the dative casemarker while another did not. Inter-subject variation is quite common in this language, both during elicitation and in natural discourse. See Genetti 1994.

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